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COMPARING SPLITS: HOW TO ACTUALLY CHOOSE ONE

How to actually decide between full-body, upper/lower, and push/pull/legs based on the days you really have.

Every few months, a new "best" training split makes the rounds online, and every time, the honest answer stays the same: there isn't one best split. There's a split that's best for you, right now, given your actual life, and figuring out which one that is comes down to answering a few honest questions instead of copying whatever's trending.

The Questions That Actually Matter

Forget "which split builds the most muscle" as your starting question, on paper, differences between well-run splits are small. The questions that actually determine which split will work for you are far more practical:

- **How many days a week can you realistically, consistently train?** Not the number you'd like to hit in a perfect week, the number you can actually show up for most weeks, including busy ones.
- **How many weeks of real training experience do you have?** Beginners need less volume and benefit more from movement practice; advanced lifters need more volume and can handle more per-session specialization.
- **How much time do you have per session?** A split that assumes 75-90 minute sessions doesn't work if you genuinely only have 45 minutes most days.

Notice that "which split is trending" isn't on that list. It shouldn't be, the split an influencer runs was chosen for their schedule and their training age, not yours.

Simple Decision Logic

Once you've honestly answered those questions, the choice mostly makes itself:

- **2-3 realistic training days a week:** full-body training. It gets you a reasonable frequency on every muscle group without needing days you don't have.
- **4 realistic training days a week:** upper/lower. It gives you more per-session focus than full-body while still hitting each muscle group twice a week, without requiring a six-day commitment.
- **5-6 realistic training days a week, with real training experience already under you:** push/pull/legs. It supports the higher per-muscle-group volume an experienced lifter needs to keep progressing, run as the 6-day rotation so frequency stays where it needs to be.

The Point Worth Repeating

The best split is the one that matches the days you will actually show up for, consistently, not the one a given influencer happens to use, and not the one that looks most "optimal" on paper. A lifter who runs an honestly-chosen full-body program three days a week, every week, for a year will out-build a lifter who bounces between full-body, upper/lower, and push/pull/legs every few weeks chasing whatever looks best that month. Switching structures constantly resets your progress on each one before it has a chance to compound, that inconsistency costs you far more than any of these three splits being individually "suboptimal" for your situation ever could. Pick a split that fits your real schedule, run it, and let consistency do the work.

How Echelon's Own Programs Apply This

This is exactly the logic Echelon's own base programs are built around, matched to each program's realistic weekly day count rather than an arbitrary ideal. The Bulking program runs a 4-day format built around an upper/lower-leaning structure, matched to a realistic four-day commitment for clients in that phase. The Muscle (Hypertrophy) program runs a 5-day format built around a push/pull/legs-leaning structure, matched to clients with more training days available and the training experience to use the extra per-session focus. Neither approach is "better" in the abstract, each is matched to the schedule it was designed for, which is the same decision you're making for yourself.

What This Means for You

- Choose a split based on your realistic weekly training days, your training experience, and your per-session time, not on what's trending.
- 2-3 days a week points to full-body, 4 days points to upper/lower, 5-6 days with real experience points to push/pull/legs.
- The split that matches the days you'll actually show up for beats the "optimal" split you can't consistently run.
- Switching splits every few weeks undermines progress more than any individual split's structure ever will.
- Echelon's own base programs follow this same logic, matched to each program's realistic weekly day count.

This article is educational and general in nature, not individualized medical or fitness advice. If you're new to resistance training or returning after an injury, work with a coach to learn proper form before increasing load or intensity, and talk to your doctor before starting a new training program if you have an underlying medical condition.